THE HOPE CONNECTION

The Fight

Five Ways a Believer Refuses to Settle — A Companion to "Make No Peace With Sin"

> "But I say, walk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh."
>
> Galatians 5:16 (ESV)

A Companion Teaching Piece from The Hope Connection

"Meeting others where they are in the Name of Jesus"

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The Fight — Five Ways a Believer Refuses to Settle

A companion teaching piece to “Make No Peace With Sin” — From The Hope Connection — Meeting others where they are in the Name of Jesus

First — So What Do I Do?

The series this piece walks beside asked you to tear up the treaty — to make no peace with sin. A fair question comes back from the kitchen table: *All right. I believe that. Now what do I actually do on Tuesday?* Because the difference between making peace with sin and making war on it is rarely a feeling. Feelings follow. The difference shows up in what a person does with the sin when nobody is watching. There are really only two ways to handle it. The first is **excusing it** — renaming it (a weakness, a habit, just how I'm wired), shrinking it ("not near as bad as what I used to do"), or blaming it on the stress, the childhood, the spouse, the job. The second is **planning to continue in it** — keeping the door unlocked. Keep the number. Keep the app. Keep the route home that passes the old place. Keep the unspoken reservation: *if it gets bad enough, I can always go back.* Different clothes, same treaty. The other handling — the one this piece walks through — is to bring the sin honestly to Christ and actively turn from it. Not perfectly. Not once, in a single burst of resolve. But honestly, actively, and again tomorrow.

One thing has to be nailed down before the first step, or every step that follows will be misunderstood: **none of this earns salvation.** Salvation is by grace alone through faith alone in Christ alone — full stop. The fight described here is fruit, never payment; it is what saved people do, not what people do to get saved. And behind the fight stands a stronger fact than the fight itself: God preserves His people, and God produces holiness in them. These five movements are simply the means He ordinarily uses — the way seed and rain are how a harvest happens. Nobody credits the seed with making the sun shine. If you are His, you are not fighting to become His. You are fighting because you are — and because the One who holds you has not made peace with your sin, even when you were tempted to.

First, the Engine: By the Spirit

Scripture: Romans 8:13; Romans 6:6–14

Before the first step, there is a word worth learning, because it names the whole war underneath the five movements that follow. Killing sin is the opposite of making peace with it — and the old word for killing sin is **mortification**: putting sinful desires to death. Not managing them. Not renaming them. Not keeping them on a leash you hold. Death. Paul gives the engine in one

verse: "For if you live according to the flesh you will die, but if by the Spirit you put to death the deeds of the body, you will live" (Romans 8:13). Notice the three words that carry the whole verse: *by the Spirit.* Not by the will. Not by the resolution. By the Spirit.

Romans 6 tells you why that death is possible. The believer's old self was crucified with Christ — "We know that our old self was crucified with him in order that the body of sin might be brought to nothing, so that we would no longer be enslaved to sin" (Romans 6:6). A dead man cannot be ruled by his old master. That is why Paul can turn from fact to command: "So you also must consider yourselves dead to sin and alive to God in Christ Jesus" (Romans 6:11). Count it true before you feel it true — and then live from the count: "Let not sin therefore reign in your mortal body, to make you obey its passions" (Romans 6:12). Sin may still knock. It may not rule. And underneath the command sits the promise: "For sin will have no dominion over you, since you are not under law but under grace" (Romans 6:14).

Let me be plain about what killing sin does not mean. It does not mean never being tempted, and it does not mean never stumbling — if it did, this piece would have no readers left, and neither would I. And it does not mean becoming sinless by your own strength, as if a tight enough grip could finish what the cross started. The blood of Christ is the basis of your forgiveness; the Spirit of Christ is the power of your holiness. The killing is real, and it is done by a power that is not yours.

God's work comes first, all the way down. He chose His people and made them new, and He sanctifies them by the Spirit: "God chose you as the firstfruits to be saved, through sanctification by the Spirit and belief in the truth" (2 Thessalonians 2:13). He gives the faith, and He keeps the fighter: "And I am sure of this, that he who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ" (Philippians 1:6). Your battle with sin is the fruit of salvation, never its cause. You are not killing sin to stay His. You are killing sin because you are His — and because He has not left you to do it alone.

John Owen, the old Puritan who wrote the book on this verse, put the charge in nine words: "Be killing sin or it will be killing you." He meant it as a summary of Romans 8:13, not as a pep talk. Sin is not a pet to manage. It is an enemy to be put to death, by the Spirit, daily, until the day it dies for good.

Two ditches run along this road, and both of them end in the same treaty. On one side is presumption: grace covers it, so why fight? Paul answers that ditch before it is even asked: "What shall we say then? Are we to continue in sin that grace may abound? By no means! How can we who died to sin still live in it?" (Romans 6:1–2). On the other side is despair: I have fallen too often to still be His. The answer to that ditch is the same truth that answers the first — you are not held by the count of your falls but by the faithfulness of the God who chose you, and He has not stopped finishing what He began. Mortification walks the road between them: neither making peace with sin, nor making peace with hopelessness.

And the Spirit does this work the way He ordinarily does it — through means. The Word, read slowly until it reads you. Prayer, on your knees, naming the thing by name. The Lord's Table, where the body broken and the blood shed for you are set before your eyes again. The fellowship of the saints, who carry your fight with you when your arms are tired. That is why the five movements that follow are not a self-help plan. The fight is fought on your knees and in the Word, not on willpower. The movements are how a believer cooperates with the power God supplies — Spirit-fed, not self-fed. Take away the means, and you are left with a man staring at his own record. Keep the means, and you have a man being led.

Read Romans 6 through 8 as the whole pattern before you read the five movements: Christ's victory, the believer's struggle, and the Spirit's power, in that order. Then the steps make sense — not as the engine, but as the wheels the Engine drives.

The Five Movements

1. Confess It by Name

Scripture: 1 John 1:9

Vagueness is the last hiding place of a settling heart. "Lord, forgive me for my sins" can be prayed without one single sin coming to mind — and that is the tell. Honest confession names the thing: what it was, when it happened, who it wounded. Not because God needs the information; He was there. Confession is agreement — calling the thing what God calls it, in God's words, with no lawyer language sanding the edges off. Set the alternative beside it and the fog clears: "If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness" (1 John 1:9). Look at the size of that promise. Forgive *and* cleanse — the record wiped and the stain worked out — and not from some unrighteousness, but from *all* of it. And look at its ground: God is *faithful and just* in forgiving confessed sin, not lenient. The debt was carried to a cross and paid; pardon is what justice looks like afterward. The real barrier to specific confession is seldom doubt about God. It is pride — the same pride that preferred the sin now prefers a fog around it. Specificity burns the fog off.

The step: Today, out loud, name one sin to God by its real name — what it was, when it happened, what it cost. Then read 1 John 1:9 back to Him as His answer, and let the verse — not your feelings about it — have the last word.

2. Fix Your Eyes, Walk by the Spirit

Scripture: Hebrews 12:1–2; Galatians 5:16

White-knuckle religion loses, because it fights by staring — at the sin, at the record, at the self — and a runner who studies his own feet stumbles over them. Hebrews changes the picture: "Therefore, since we are surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses, let us also lay aside every weight, and sin which clings so closely, and let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is seated at the right hand of the throne of God" (Hebrews 12:1–2). Notice the two things laid aside: every *weight* — the not-sinful-in-themselves burdens that tangle the legs, the exhaustion, the clutter, the company and the hours that leave a person defenseless — and the sin that *clings*, the one that knows your name and your schedule. And notice the strategy that replaces the staring: *looking to Jesus.* He is the founder of your faith and its perfecter — its author and its finisher. The race is not won by the man with the tightest jaw; it is run by the man whose eyes stay on the One who started it in him. Paul puts the same medicine in walking clothes: "But I say, walk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh" (Galatians 5:16). It is promise-shaped, not threat-shaped. The way through is a walk — daily, unglamorous, led — and the Spirit is not a surge of willpower to summon but a Person to ask, to follow, and to be fed by, through the Word, through prayer, through the ordinary means of grace. Feed the walk, and the flesh goes hungry.

The step: This morning, before the known battle arrives, pray it in one breath: "Holy Spirit, I cannot win this in my own strength — walk me through today." Then, when the moment comes, look at the cross before you look at your record.

3. Cut the Supply Lines

Scripture: Matthew 5:29–30

Jesus does not negotiate with sin; He talks like a surgeon. "If your right eye causes you to sin, tear it out and throw it away. For it is better that you lose one of your members than that your whole body be thrown into hell. And if your right hand causes you to sin, cut it off and throw it away. For it is better that you lose one of your members than that your whole body go into hell" (Matthew 5:29–30). He is not commanding self-harm — He is making a cost argument in the strongest picture available. Whatever repeatedly hands you over to sin must be dealt with ruthlessly, and the cost of *not* dealing with it is the higher cost. Every settled sin lives on supply lines. It is fed by something: a route, a phone, an app, an unaccounted hour, an unaccounted twenty dollars, a relationship that always ends in the same place, a first step that everyone involved knows is never the last step. The man making peace keeps his supply lines maintained and calls it realism. The man at war asks one plain question — *where does this thing eat?* — and cuts it there: the routine changes, the access closes, the relationship gets distance, or ends. It will cost something real: convenience, comfort, maybe a friendship, maybe money. Jesus already did that math out loud. Better to lose the member than the whole body. Lose the convenience. Keep the life.

I know that treaty from the inside, friend. For more than thirty years I walked into programs still holding the controls with both hands. I would surrender the substance, maybe — on my terms, for a while — while the man himself stayed right where he was, running the show. That is the treaty that charges the most: a partial surrender that leaves the real ruler in place. My own way charged me thirty years, and it charged me rehabs I worked like negotiations and promises I broke before the ink dried. The supply line that mattered most was not a place or a phone. It was me, still holding the controls. Cut that one, and the rest of the doors start to close.

The step: Name the one open door your sin walks through most — and close it today with a deed, not just a decision: delete it, block it, change the route, hand the access to someone you trust. One door. Today.

4. Drag It Into the Light

Scripture: James 5:16; Hebrews 3:13; Galatians 6:1

Sin prefers the dark the way mold prefers a damp cellar; secrecy is its climate control. Confession to God is the first light, and James commands a second one: "Therefore, confess your sins to one another and pray for one another, that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous person has great power as it is working" (James 5:16). To *one another* — not to everybody, and not to the whole internet, but to a living person: a mature believer, a pastor, someone who will pray for you and then do the part we usually skip — ask you about it again. James ties the telling to *healing*, and long experience says the same: a sin spoken out loud loses half its authority in the saying of it. Why the daily, mutual watch? "But exhort one another every day, as long as it is called 'today,' that none of you may be hardened by the deceitfulness of sin" (Hebrews 3:13). Sin hardens by deception, and deception is a slow drip nobody feels — so God appoints other people as the early-warning system. And He instructs the receivers, too: "Brothers, if anyone is caught in any transgression, you who are spiritual should restore him in a spirit of gentleness. Keep watch on yourself, lest you too be tempted" (Galatians 6:1). Restore. Gently. The local church is God's appointed place for all of it — preaching that names the sin, encouragement that carries the fighter, correction that loves too much to look away. I will tell you plain: I learned in recovery rooms, long before I could say it in a church, that the thing you say out loud can no longer own you in silence.

The step: This week, pick one believer you trust and say the true sentence: "Here is the thing I am actually fighting." Ask for two things — prayer, and that they ask you about it again next week.

5. Keep Coming Back

Scripture: Hebrews 12:10–11; Philippians 1:6; Galatians 6:9

Here is where fighters quietly quit — not usually in the fall itself, but in the getting up: the tenth time, the hundredth. The settled man and the stumbling man may fall over the same sin in the same year. The difference is the return. Scripture speaks of God's correction in family language, not courtroom language: "he disciplines us for our good, that we may share his holiness. For the moment all discipline seems painful rather than pleasant, but later it yields the peaceful fruit of righteousness to those who have been trained by it" (Hebrews 12:10–11). Discipline is what a Father does with *sons*. Its presence is evidence of belonging; its aim is shared holiness; its harvest is peace — but the harvest word is *later*, and it belongs to those who stay in the training instead of transferring out of it. Underneath all the returning stands the promise that makes returning possible: "And I am sure of this, that he who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ" (Philippians 1:6). The completion of you is God's project, under God's guarantee. Your assignment is the next return; His assignment is the finished work. Paul gives the farmer's version of the same patience: "And let us not grow weary of doing good, for in due season we will reap, if we do not give up" (Galatians 6:9). A crop has a season. The man who quits in the middle of the field forfeits a harvest that was coming on schedule.

The step: If you fell today, return today — not after a penalty period of feeling bad enough. Confess it, receive the forgiveness, get up, and do the next right thing before the sun goes down.

When You Fall Tonight

> It is 1 AM, and you just fell. You are reading this on a phone screen in the dark, and the shame is already doing its work — telling you to hide until morning and feel bad enough to earn your way back. Do not listen to it. Here is what to do in the next ten minutes.
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> Do not hide till morning. Confess it by name right there, in the dark, out loud if you can: "If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness" (1 John 1:9). Then reach for the one person who already knows — text them, call them, let them pray with you tonight, not next week. That is what James 5:16 is for.
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> And then get up. Not after a penalty period. Not when you feel ready. Now. The promise has not expired while you were falling: "he who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ" (Philippians 1:6). Forgiveness does not start in the morning. It already started. Get up, drink some water, do the next right thing — and let tomorrow begin from forgiveness, not from hiding.

The Hand That Holds the Fighter

Five movements, and not one of them heroic. That is by design. God keeps ordinary people by ordinary means, held inside an extraordinary promise: the founder and perfecter of your faith does not misplace His own. Your grip on Him was never the thing holding you. His grip on you is. If this piece has put words to your war, do one more thing this week: read **Galatians 5 and 6** slowly, the way you'd read a letter written to you. There is the war named — flesh against Spirit, with no truce offered. There is the fruit promised, the fruit no fighter can manufacture and every Spirit-led walker grows: "But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control; against such things there is no law" (Galatians 5:22–23). And there are the burdens carried shoulder to shoulder, the reaping that comes in due season, the God who is not mocked and who is not finished. Read it, mark it, and bring this week's fight into its light — then get up, and keep coming back. He will complete what He began.

A Prayer to Pray Aloud

> Father in heaven, I come to You honestly — not hiding, not bargaining, and not making peace with the sin that still pulls at me. I cannot kill it in my own strength, and I will not pretend otherwise. By Your Spirit, put to death the deeds of my body. Forgive me through the blood of Jesus, and cleanse me from all unrighteousness. Give me the next step: the door to close, the person to tell, the return to make. Hold me when my own grip fails, because Your grip does not. Finish the good work You began in me, and make me holy the way only You can. In the name of Jesus, who died for my sin and lives to keep me. Amen.

Keep Reading

1. **Romans 6–8** — the whole pattern: Christ's victory, the believer's struggle, and the Spirit's power.
2. **Galatians 5–6** — walking by the Spirit, and the fruit no fighter can manufacture.
3. **Psalm 51** — David's confession: a clean heart asked for, not earned.
4. **Psalm 32** — the relief of forgiven sin, and the misery of keeping silent.
5. **1 John 1** — walking in the light, and the God who is faithful and just to forgive.
6. **Hebrews 12** — the Father's discipline, and the peaceful fruit of righteousness that comes later.

Meeting others where they are in the Name of Jesus

Christ Proclaimed. Jesus is Lord.

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